

NOMAD

by

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INT. OFFICE SPACE - DEAD SALES DEPARTMENT - NIGHT

Sales emptied out in the spring. Nobody came for the furniture.

Half the floor is dark. In the lit half, three men who should have gone home four hours ago.

WILL, CAIRNS and JOHN (30s) are building a golf course out of a dead department. A ramp made of binders. A water hazard that is a mop bucket with water in it.

Cairns is taking the old CEO's office door off its hinges with a butter knife.

CAIRNS

He's not using it.

JOHN

He's not using it because he's in Lisbon.

CAIRNS

Then he's really not using it.

The door comes free. All three of them carry it. It is much heavier than any of them expected, and they get it eight feet before they have to put it down and stand there breathing.

They lean it against a filing cabinet. A ramp. John writes 7 on a Post-it and sticks it to the wall.

Will putts. The ball climbs the door, runs the length of the cabinet, and drops into a coffee mug on the far side.

A silence while all three of them work out that it went in.

Then they lose it – the helpless laughter of people who are extremely tired and nowhere near going home.

Later. Backs against the cabinets, on the carpet, shoes off.

CAIRNS

Nine years I've been on this floor.

JOHN

Eight.

WILL

Six.

CAIRNS
(to the ceiling)
Nine years. You know what I've got
out of it?
(beat)
A really good chair.

It's a joke. It doesn't land like one. Nobody says anything
for a second longer than they should.

Then John throws a golf ball at him and it's over.

Later still. Cairns is trying to teach them something and it
is not going well.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)
No. No. Fist, fist, roll it, then
the thing.

WILL
What thing.

CAIRNS
The thing. The little –
(does something with his
hand that means nothing)
That.

They try it. They get it wrong. They try it again and get it
wrong in a completely new way. Will is laughing so hard he
has to hold onto the cabinet.

JOHN
This is the stupidest –

CAIRNS
It's not stupid. It's ours.

They go again. Fist, fist, roll – and then a small dumb
extra beat on the end. A half-second of nothing, both hands
open, like putting something down.

They get it.

Cairns points at the two of them like a man who has won an
argument.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)
Again.

They do it again. Clean.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)
Again.

John steps in for the third slot and does it deliberately, catastrophically wrong.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)
Out. You're out. You're banned for
life.

JOHN
(delighted)
I don't want it.

He wants it.

Will and Cairns run it once more, fast, already muscle memory. Cairns holds the last open-handed beat a moment longer than he needs to, looking at it.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)
That's a good one.

On the far side of the floor the lights click off on a timer. Nobody moves.

MAIN TITLE: NOMAD

INT. OFFICE SPACE - DAY

A floor at its midpoint. Bodies among empty desks. Nobody looks up.

CAIRNS (30s, loud, likeable) packs his desk into a printer-paper box, performing an exit for a floor that isn't watching. Only WILL and JOHN are.

CAIRNS
(raising an invisible
glass, to the empty desks)
To four incredible years. Truly.
Some of the best emails of my life.

Nobody looks up. He toasts anyway.

A ROBOT BOSS — a monitor on a wheeled stand — rolls up. The boss's face fills it: warm, attentive, always available. Cairns puts a hand to his heart and gives it a review.

CAIRNS
Five stars. Would be exploited
again.

ROBOT BOSS
Thanks for the feedback!

A half-beat late. John and Will crack up.

Will's laugh catches for a second. He knows that lag – he knows it the way a piano tuner knows a flat note. He looks at the screen a moment too long.

Then he lets it go. It's a Tuesday. It's a joke.

INT. BOSS'S HOUSE - CONTINUOUS

The real boss, mid golf-sim swing. The office feed props against a lamp, unwatched.

On it, his own face is still working – nodding, agreeing, answering for him. It has been answering for him all morning.

INT. OFFICE SPACE - ELEVATOR BANK - CONTINUOUS

Will and John flank Cairns, carrying nothing. Happy for him. A little jealous.

CAIRNS
One fee. That's the whole thing.
They handle everything.

WILL
Everything meaning what.

CAIRNS
Everything meaning everything.

JOHN
Visa?

CAIRNS
Handled.

WILL
By who?

A gap, small. Cairns fills it fast.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)
By – they've got people. It's a whole thing. Michelle walks you through it.

Neither of them asks who Michelle is. He has already moved on.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)
You should come. Both of you. I'm serious.

He says it like a joke, so that it can be one if they don't take it.

Nobody takes it.

The elevator arrives. Cairns steps in, turns, and raises a fist.

Will meets it. Fist, fist, roll, and the dumb open-handed beat on the end.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)
Next year. I'm telling you.

The doors close on him mid-sell.

INT. OFFICE SPACE - MOMENTS LATER

Cairns' desk, cleared to the laminate – except for a branded welcome folder, left behind on purpose, squared to the edge to be found.

John eyes the empty chair.

JOHN
I always liked that chair.

He drops into it, gives it a spin. Will cracks up despite himself.

The chair slows. Nobody touches the folder.

SUPER: ONE YEAR LATER

INT. OFFICE SPACE - MORNING

The same floor, mostly empty. Motion-sensor lights click on ahead of Will in sequence – a runway for nobody.

He passes dark departments. Cairns' desk, untouched, the folder gathering a year of dust.

At 8:55 the coffee machine brews a full pot. Will pours its only cup.

INT. OFFICE SPACE - WILL'S DESK - DAY

A queue of faces. Machine verdicts. One button: APPROVE. Will clicks. A streak counter climbs.

A face, machine-verified 98%. Will stops. Replays three seconds – the man is asked about his childhood; his eyes go nowhere.

Will overrides: SYNTHETIC. The system concedes. His streak resets to zero. No one looks up.

On his monitor: SYSTEM 99.1 / WILL 96.8 – TOP HUMAN PERFORMER.

To log back in, Will re-verifies himself – face to the camera, look left, look right.

INSERT - SCREEN

IDENTITY: LOW CONFIDENCE – RETRY.

BACK TO SCENE. He sighs, does it again. VERIFIED. Routine.

Later. The dashboard, a river of decisions. Will spots a fraud he's sure of. INTERVENE.

His screen dims. A coaching module auto-plays – "Trusting Your Tools," a cheerful presenter who blinks at perfectly regular intervals. In the corner, the system clears his case without him.

His screen blinks – an incoming call cuts straight through the coaching module. CAIRNS, poolside, sun, abundance.

CAIRNS

You wouldn't believe this place.
Everything's two-for-one –
everything.

He lowers his voice like it's a secret.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)

You know how long since I clicked
approve on anything? Since anybody
checked I was –
(waving it off)
I don't even remember my own login,
man.

Two GIRLS flank him. To each other, dry, not for Cairns:

GIRL 1

(in Spanish; subtitled)
A year here and he still points at
the menu.

GIRL 2

(in Spanish; subtitled)
Give him another. He'll own the
building.

Cairns doesn't understand a word. Delighted:

CAIRNS (CONT'D)
See? They love it here too. Anyway
— you know I'm tight with Michelle.
Say the word, you're set up by
Friday.

The girls pull him from frame.

CAIRNS (O.S.) (CONT'D)
Love you, buddy!

The screen stays on. The three run to the pool. Cairns
throws one girl in.

Will watches. A tinge of jealousy in it.

JOHN (O.S.)
Is that Cairns? Nice.

Will kills the tab and turns. John, holding six beers — for
the two of them.

INT. DEAD SALES DEPARTMENT - MINI-PUTT COURSE - LATER

The lights are on. Hole 7 uses the old CEO's office door as
a ramp.

JOHN
You know I've never even been out
of the country?

WILL
Neither had Cairns.

JOHN
Yeah, well. Some of us like it
here.

He doesn't sound sure of that. Will lines up a putt, then
stops.

WILL
Who's Michelle?

JOHN
What?

WILL
He keeps saying Michelle. Like we
know her.

JOHN
The Service is a company.

WILL
Right.

JOHN
Since when do companies have a
first name?

Neither of them has an answer, and neither of them wants one badly enough to keep going.

Will sinks the putt, doesn't celebrate. Somewhere else entirely.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

A facetime with family. A parent, bad connection, distracted. The call ends first from their side.

On his laptop, a real-estate listing: the family home, priced to sell. Everyone scattered. He scrolls past it.

His building – lockboxes on every door, rolling suitcases in the hall, a different set of strangers each weekend. He's the last person who actually lives on his floor.

He opens the Service page. The logo he's walked past on Cairns' dead desk for a year.

INT. SERVICE STOREFRONT - DAY

An office park. The Service sits between a vape shop and a notary. Brochure rack, folding chairs, a paradise reel looping over a dying pothos.

On the reel, a family laughs a half-beat late.

Will clocks it instantly, professionally – and files it where it costs him nothing. Everybody renders their b-roll now. Nobody flies a crew for a brochure.

A bored coordinator checks Will in like a dentist's office.

INSERT - PASSPORT

A scanner's green line crosses it.

BACK TO SCENE. Face capture: look left, look right, read this aloud. Will jokes that he does this for a living.

COORDINATOR
Then you know it's painless.

The coordinator winks. Entirely, boringly human.

COORDINATOR (CONT'D)
One more. For the file – describe
your dream place. Take your time.

WILL
(to camera, easy,
unprompted)
High floor. Light in the morning.
Somewhere I don't have to explain
myself to anybody.

He means it as a throwaway. The camera keeps rolling a beat
after he's done.

INT. WILL'S CAR - PARKING LOT - CONTINUOUS

The email arrives before he's out of the lot. MICHELLE –
template-warm, exclamation points, a scheduling link.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

Michelle's welcome preview: an automated ad starring WILL.
His face, his walk, composited into Cairns' paradise. "See
yourself there."

He watches himself live the ad, delighted. He says his name
for the personalization. Says it again, excited. Grinning.

INSERT - SCREEN

A checkbox fills: CONFIRM MY DETAILS. It plays his own face
back to him – and for half a second his eyes look wrong.

BACK TO SCENE. His hand is on the scrub bar before he knows
why. He drags it back. Watches the three seconds again. Then
again, frame by frame, the way he has nine hundred times
this year for strangers.

He is one keystroke from the form he fills out for a living.

He closes the window instead. Compression. Everybody's
compression is bad.

INT. OFFICE SPACE - DAY

The ROBOT BOSS rolls to the center of the floor. An all-
hands. On its screen: the real boss, on a treadmill
somewhere sun-bleached, barely winded.

BOSS
(V.O., warm, unbothered)
Big news, team – the floor's
closing! Full remote by the new
year. Genuinely so excited for
what's next.

A half-beat late, he raises a coconut water like a toast.
The feed freezes on his smile a second too long, then cuts.

Will counts the lag without meaning to. Four tenths.

Then: the treadmill, the coconut water, a resort's bad wifi,
a satellite, a Tuesday. A hundred honest reasons, and he
only needs one.

He picks one.

John's answer: the last day in the office is the MINI-PUTT
CHAMPIONSHIP. He starts the bracket.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

John helps Will pack. He finds Will's putter, tapes WILL on
the grip, keeps it.

Will holds it up, half-laughing.

WILL
It's a putt-putt bracket, John.

JOHN
It's the last one.

It sits there. Will promises to be back for it. Half-
listening.

INT. APARTMENT, MEXICO CITY - DAY

A viewing. High floor. Morning light. Perfect.

And not finished emptying. Boxes taped and stacked by the
door. A wall of nail holes where pictures were. Down the
door frame, a child's height marks in pencil, eleven years
of them.

Somebody's mail is still in the slot.

AGENT
Unit's just come available – they
don't usually turn this fast. You'd
be moving in the same week they're
moving out.

Will looks at the height marks. He understands exactly what he's looking at.

AGENT (CONT'D)

Interested?

He takes it.

EXT. MEXICO CITY - DAY

A market. Will haggles a vendor down over a bag of limes – forty pesos, nothing – and wins, and is delighted. Two stalls on, he overtips a man for a coffee by three times the price of the coffee, and is delighted by that too.

At a counter he orders in English. The girl answers in English. He tries the Spanish for thank you and she says it back to him, correctly. He doesn't hear the correction.

He texts Cairns on landing. Cairns is warm, specific, flaky – "in Oaxaca for a thing, next week for SURE, I already told everyone you're here."

At a rooftop party, a flicker of familiarity – the light, the pool, the shape of the night. Like a place he's already been sold. He shrugs it off.

He passes two locals mid-conversation, subtitled for us – about the building on the corner that emptied inside a month. Eleven apartments. Nobody knows where the fourth floor went. The new ones are never home.

The building sits behind them, unremarkable. Will walks through the shot without hearing a word of it.

At the tail end of the block, a man on the curb. Gaunt, wrecked, talking – fast, urgent, to anyone who passes.

It's CAIRNS.

He can speak. He has been saying his own name all morning. He holds his phone up to a passing face like ID.

INSERT - PHONE

IDENTITY NOT VERIFIED – REFERENCE ON FILE.

BACK TO SCENE. He turns the screen around and starts explaining it, again, to somebody already gone. There is no reason to look at a man the machine has already answered.

He reaches – not quite toward Will, just toward the street.

And Will sees him. For one full second, Will sees him.

Then the reflex he has spent a year putting down puts this down too. Phone up. He steps around, and is gone.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT, MEXICO CITY - NIGHT / INT. DEAD
OFFICE - NIGHT - INTERCUT

Will steps out of a rooftop party to take the call, and then doesn't go back in. Behind him, through glass, people he doesn't know are having a good night.

John walks the dark floor with the phone in one hand and a putter under his arm.

JOHN
Cairns liked my bracket post. So
you better be in.

WILL
Course.

JOHN
It's gonna be everybody.

Will looks back through the glass at the party.

WILL
Yeah.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT, MEXICO CITY - NIGHT

The poolside frame. Cairns, still selling, still "next week."

CAIRNS
Just got up. Best sleep of my life
down here.

Will raises a fist to the webcam and starts their handshake. Muscle memory.

The likeness follows. It knows the handshake – but comes a half-beat late and lands one move wrong. The move the real Cairns never misses.

Same laugh, 0.4 off. It slides back into the sell without a seam.

Four seconds of Will fully awake. His hand still up. The call does not end. It goes on, pleasantly – Will managing a goodnight.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)
I love you, man.

A half-beat late. Will closes the laptop and sits very still in the best apartment he's ever had.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT, MEXICO CITY - NIGHT - LATER

Desk lamp. Blue screen light. Two video windows side by side: an old real Cairns clip and tonight's call. Will drags them frame by frame.

A call Cairns swore he'd just woken up for. The light behind him is five o'clock light. On the far wall, reflected in the water, three pixels of a clock – wrong.

The laugh, isolated on a waveform: 0.4 late. The same 0.4, in the same place, every time he laughs. No human is that consistent.

Then the thing he's actually hunting for. He runs the call metadata. Every message from Cairns – every call, for months – pings the same coordinates. Will drops them on a map.

One building. Twenty minutes away. He has the address because he found it.

EXT. CAIRNS' BUILDING - DAY

From below. Monolithic. It fills the frame.

He doesn't have an appointment. He has an address, and nobody knows he has it.

INT. CAIRNS' BUILDING - DAY

Mid-morning – the lobby's dead, the front desk mid shift-change. Will slips in behind a delivery cart, badge-less, unremarked. Nobody's watching the door; the cameras are watching the residents. The service stairs.

Upstairs: nothing. No set, no pool. An empty floor – chairs, capture rigs like the storefront's, racks of humming servers.

He knows this room. He has sat in the client-side version of it. He built reports off what rooms like this produce.

A fire door stands propped on somebody's cigarette break. Through it: the RENDER FARM.

An operator types a line. A poolside evening assembles in seconds – Cairns' pool, water that has never been wet.

On another screen, a girl who doesn't exist is thrown laughing into it. A slider drags her laugh warmer.

Along one wall, a rack of LOCATION PLATES – scanned, catalogued, resold. A rooftop. A string of bulbs. A city he was standing in last week.

On a third screen: familiar faces, likenesses at work, attending standups.

On a fourth, an outbound queue – hundreds of warm, exclamation-pointed emails going out at once. Every one of them signed MICHELLE.

Across the room, an operator clocks him in a doorway reflection. Doesn't stand, doesn't call out. Just reaches over and taps something in, and goes back to work.

Will has perhaps four minutes and no idea how many he has.

On one screen, mid-generation: WILL'S OWN welcome ad, refining. Him, poolside, saying things he's never said. The line about the high floor and the morning light plays back, exactly as he gave it.

In the corner of it, a readout he has looked at every working day of his life: WILL 96.8. Beside it, the model's number. Higher.

From the next row – WILL'S OWN LAUGH. The real one. He follows his own voice.

The worst screen in the building: CAIRNS' LIKENESS on a call with WILL'S LIKENESS. Poolside together. Their in-jokes. Version numbers in the corner.

Will slips out. Nobody stops him. Nobody has to.

The fire door has swung shut behind him. No handle on this side.

He heads for the service stairs – and finds them held. Building security, apologetic, procedural: anyone without a resident badge gets verified before they leave. Standard, since an incident last month.

The main stairwell, then. The lift lobby. Every way down runs through the same desk, and the desk is the point.

He goes where they point. He is still, on some level he will spend the rest of his life examining, certain this will clear.

INT. DEAD SALES DEPARTMENT - DAY / INT. VERIFICATION ROOM - DAY - INTERCUT

In the DEAD SALES DEPARTMENT: last day. The floor half-dismantled – desks tagged, cables coiled, the coffee machine unplugged. A paper banner sags at one corner. The bracket: most names never filled in, one crossed out and rewritten smaller – WILL (REMOTE?).

John, in a homemade referee shirt, by hole 7. Two other people, coats on, already leaving. Then just John.

Two beers. Will's putter leans against the hole. Reserved.

In the VERIFICATION ROOM: Will sits in the chair – good light, a liveness rig, the machinery he's used his whole career.

Nine years of being right about this machine. He puts his face to it.

It reads the polished model as authentic. It flags the live man as SYNTHETIC. The examiner reads a number. The number is confident.

INSERT - SCREEN

STATUS: SYNTHETIC · RETAINED FOR REFERENCE.

Behind him, a wall of numbered lockers. Most are tagged. Some have been cleared and not refilled – the ones the model no longer needs to check itself against.

One tag is readable. A first name and a version number: CAIRNS · v6.

An attendant peels a numbered tag from a sheet of them, clips it to Will's collar. Inventory now. A hand guides him, unhurried, toward a door – a specimen the model keeps until it doesn't. He doesn't fight it. On paper, he isn't here.

The DEAD SALES DEPARTMENT: John's laptop CHIMES. An incoming call.

He answers – and we see it before he does.

The poolside frame. The water. The light. The one we have now watched twice.

"WILL" fills it. Tanned. Easy. Glowing.

He is warm. He is specific. He knows about the bracket. He knows about hole 7. He knows about the putter.

WILL
Can't make it, buddy. I'm gutted.
But listen –

The pitch. Come down here. He'll set him up. There's a woman, Michelle – one fee, handles everything. By Friday.

John doesn't smile.

Behind the likeness, the water moves – not wrong exactly. Just not the way water moves.

Something crosses John's face. Not delight, not alarm. Something he can't place. The rhythm's a little off. The warmth's a shade too smooth.

For one second, he almost catches it.

WILL (CONT'D)
I love you, man.

A half-beat late.

The call ends. John sits alone in the half-dismantled floor, lit by the screen. The putter behind him. Reserved.

He reaches for his phone.

He starts to type back.

We stay on John. His face, lit by the screen. Hold.

CUT TO BLACK.

THE END

